

ISSUE 63
SEPTEMBER 2025

ESPI Insights

SPACE SECTOR WATCH

Finland awards €158 million contract to ICEYE for SAR satellites



Credit: ICEYE

Finnish Defence Forces have awarded a €158 million contract to ICEYE for the supply of Synthetic Aperture Radar (SAR) satellites. The contract follows a Letter of Intent signed between the Finnish Ministry of Defence and ICEYE in June 2025 and is intended to enhance Finland's space-based surveillance and intelligence capabilities. In addition to the satellites, the procurement includes the systems and equipment necessary for the Finnish Defence Forces to establish an independent space-based surveillance capability.

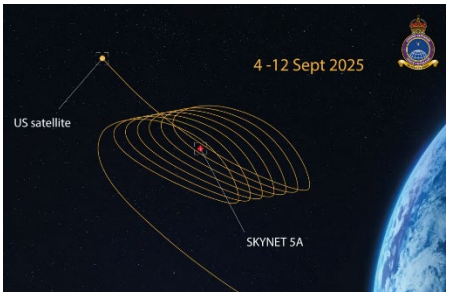
The contract value also covers options to extend the lifespan of the satellites and further expand the system in the future. While the number of satellites and a deployment timeline are yet to be disclosed, the Finnish Ministry of Defence has indicated the swift deployment of an initial capability.

NATO invests $728 million in new space capabilities

NATO has invested $728 million into a "capability program plan" to expand the Space Operations Centre located at Ramstein AFB in Germany. The funding is intended to provide the centre with the mission system, contractors, training, and data required to support battle space awareness and command-and-control functions in space. Part of this initiative involves the development of a new NATO space data lake, known as the Allied Exchange Environment (AXE), which is modelled on the US Space Force's Unified Data Library, but designed as a separate system for NATO use.

AXE will serve as a secure hub for space domain awareness and space-based Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance (ISR) data, and is expected to be populated with information from the Allied Persistent Surveillance from Space (APSS) program.

UK and US conduct first joint military operation in space



Credit: SpaceNews

The UK Space Command and US Space Command have conducted their first joint military operation in space. The "Rendezvous Proximity Operation" involved repositioning a US satellite into close range of **UK geostationary communications spacecraft SKYNET 5A to inspect and validate its status.** Both satellites were travelling at approximately 11,000 kilometres per hour at an altitude of nearly 36,000 kilometres above the Earth. The operation was delivered under US-led space coalition "Multinational Force – Operation Olympic Defender" and symbolises allied cooperation in an increasingly militarised domain.

DRC secures up to $400 million for national satellite project with Monacosat



Credit: SSI-Monaco

The Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) has partnered with Monacosat for the development of a national communications satellite aimed at advancing digital connectivity across the country. The project has already secured financial commitments of up to $400 million from a partner bank to support the launch of the satellite. Once operational, the satellite is expected to strengthen internet coverage across the DRC, where currently only a third of the population has access to mobile internet.

High-level discussions relating to the initiative were held at the presidential offices in Kinshasa between DRC President Félix Tshisekedi and Monacosat's representative Jean-Philippe Anvam, alongside the Minister of Digital Economy and the Minister of Posts and Telecommunications. This follows a recent visit by Fidelity Bank of Nigeria, during which the bank's support for the project was confirmed, as well as plans to launch a joint task force with the Ministry of Digital Economy to explore funding mechanisms for the satellite.

Senior DRC government officials have long been advocating for increased satellite connectivity as a way to overcome the high costs and slow rollout of the country's 50,000-kilometre national fibre backbone, part of the Digital Horizon 2025 plan. This commitment is reflected by a recent Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) that was signed between Monacosat and the Minister of Posts, Telecommunications and Digital Economy to acquire satellite capacity from the Monacosat-1 platform.

Poland allocates €470 million for six satellites as IRIS2 contribution

Poland's Ministry of Funds and Regional Policy has announced the allocation of €470 million for six secure communications satellites and supporting ground infrastructure. The project forms part of Poland's National Recovery and Resilience Plan and contributes to the EU's IRIS2 programme. The initiative aims to ensure secure communications for Poland's security services and enable local industry to join global space supply chains. This follows earlier investments in Earth Observation, including the €85 million CAMILA satellite constellation.

CNES signs €31 million contract with UNIVITY for 5G connectivity demonstration

CNES has signed a €31 million contract with French startup UNIVITY and telecommunications and broadcasting company TDF to carry out an in-orbit demonstration of satellite-enabled 5G connectivity. The project is co-funded under the France2030 initiative and is valued at €44 million, with UNIVITY and TDF covering 30% of the cost. The core technology will be developed by UNIVITY, which was founded in 2022 with the aim to develop a very LEO satellite constellation to provide high-speed, low-latency internet on a global scale. UNIVITY's regenerative 5G mmWave payload flew on a SpaceX Falcon 9 rideshare mission in June, with the company expecting to launch two prototype satellites in 2027 ahead of a larger rollout from 2028 to 2030.

TDF will host and operate three gateway stations, two of which will be in France and the other overseas, to ensure interoperability with terrestrial networks. The first phase, which focuses on technical specifications and use case studies, is already underway, while the second phase is due to begin in April 2026 and will cover the assembly, integration, testing, and in-orbit demonstration of the first VLEO 5G satellites. The project is being positioned as a step toward a French alternative to the SpaceX Starlink network.

Airbus contracts Arianespace for SATCOMBw-3 satellites for German Armed Forces

Airbus Defence and Space has selected Arianespace to launch two SATCOMBw-3 communications satellites for the German Armed Forces. This follows the €2.1 billion contract in July 2024 tasking Airbus with the development and deployment of a next-generation secure communications system to replace the SATCOMBw-2 constellation launched on Ariane 5 rockets in 2009 and 2010. The programme covers the development of two geostationary satellites, the ground segment, their launch, and the constellation's operation over a 15-year period.



Credit: CNES/ESA/Arianespace

China promotes D2D services with new guidelines and licensing

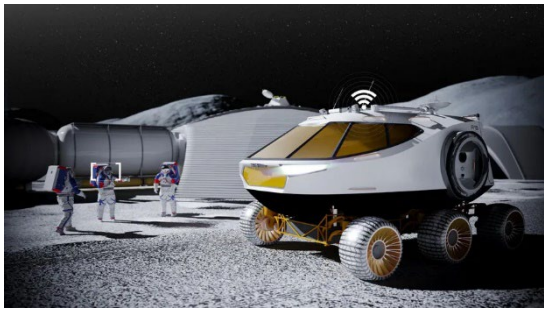
China's Ministry of Industry and Information Technology (MIIT) has issued its "Guiding Opinions on Optimizing Business Access to Promote the Development of the Satellite Communications Industry" and licensed China Unicom to operate satellite mobile services, highlighting a shift towards promoting direct-to-device (D2D) services. The guidelines explicitly endorse D2D satellite services, including direct phone-to-satellite links, and encourage partnerships between China's major telecommunications operators and satellite companies. They also promote commercial trials for IoT services and outline a long-term goal of large-scale adoption by 2030, targeting over 10 million users.

NASA and NOAA launch three missions investigating solar activity and influence

On 24 September 2025, a SpaceX Falcon 9 rocket successfully carried three scientific spacecraft into space from NASA's Kennedy Space Center in Florida. The payload included NASA's Interstellar Mapping and Acceleration Probe (IMAP), Carruthers Geocorona Observatory, and NOAA's Space Weather Follow On-Lagrange 1 (SWFO-L1). The three missions, jointly led by NASA and the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), aim to improve the space weather readiness of the United States by investigating the influence of the Sun throughout the solar system. **As part of the IMAP mission, the UK is contributing the MAG instrument**, a highly sensitive magnetometer that will measure the strength and direction of magnetic fields, supported by £4.2 million in funding from the UK Space Agency. The spacecraft are now on the way to Lagrange Point 1 (L1), approximately 1.6 million kilometres from Earth, where operations are expected to begin in early 2026.

NASA awards Solstar Space contract for lunar Wi-Fi systems

NASA has awarded Solstar Space with a contract for the development of commercial Wi-Fi access points for the agency's Artemis and Commercial Lunar Payload Services (CLPS) programmes. Solstar is a New Mexico-based company specialised in persistent communications services for space systems. The $150,000 award falls under NASA's Small Business Innovation Research programme, tasking Solstar with the creation of preliminary designs for Wi-Fi access points for human landing systems, lunar rovers, instruments, payloads, sensors, spacesuits, and tablet computers. As part of this initiative, Solstar is developing a Lunar Wi-Fi Access Point (LWIFI-AP), engineered to withstand harsh lunar conditions and enable reliable communications, supporting real-time mission data, navigation, and scientific collaboration.



Credit: Solstar Space

IN OTHER NEWS

ESA and Avio sign contract for reusable upper stage demo

ESA and Avio have signed a €40 million contract to advance the in-flight demonstration of a reusable upper stage. The 24-month programme includes the assessment of requirements, the design, and key technologies for a future demonstrator capable of being reused after returning to Earth.

Australia launches ASII to strengthen domestic capabilities

Australia has launched the Australasian Space Innovation Institute (ASII), a new non-for-profit space organisation aimed at accelerating the use of industry research and strengthening Australia's domestic space capabilities.

EU Commission proposes Defence Space Shield

The European Commission has proposed four defence projects ahead of an informal meeting among EU leaders in Copenhagen. The defence projects include the Defence Space Shield, a drone wall against Russian aerial aggression, the Air Defence Shield, and the Eastern Flank Watch.

SpaceX launches 21 satellites for Transport Layer

On 10 September 2025, a SpaceX Falcon 9 rocket launched 21 satellites from Vandenberg Space Force Base into LEO for the U.S. Space Force's Space Development Agency, marking the first deployment of satellites for the "Transport Layer".

AfSA and MEDEF International sign partnership

The African Space Agency (AfSA) and MEDEF International have signed a three-year partnership to advance Africa's space sector. The agreement addresses five key areas, namely the development of the African space sector, skills transfer and knowledge sharing, space economic diplomacy, space-dedicated business forums, and regulatory frameworks.

Callisto flight postponed to 2027

In a recent call for proposals, CNES has revealed the delay of the inaugural flight of the Callisto reusable rocket demonstrator, which has been postponed from 2026 to 2027. The Cooperative Action Leading to Launcher Innovation in Stage Toss-back Operations (Callisto) is a collaborative project between CNES, DLR, and JAXA.

Airbus, Leonardo and Thales advance negotiations on merger

Airbus, Thales and Leonardo are advancing negotiations on a potential European space alliance aimed at consolidating the satellite sector and competing with U.S. players such as Starlink. While no agreement has yet been reached, negotiations are underway, and Airbus has suggested a preliminary deal could be signed by the end of 2025. The proposed venture is valued at around €10 billion and aims to increase Europe's competitiveness in the space sector.

Planet Labs plans production of next-generation satellites in Germany

Planet Labs has announced plans to establish a satellite production facility in Berlin for its next-generation high-resolution Pelican satellites. The investments are valued at more than eight figures and will double the total production capacity of the Pelican constellation. The decision follows a €240 million contract awarded by the German government in July 2025 aimed at supporting peace and stability across Europe. Under the agreement, Planet Labs will provide dedicated capacity and direct downlink services on Pelican satellites over certain European regions. **Berlin was chosen for its proximity to the government** and the fact that it already serves as the company's European headquarters.

Eutelsat signs partnership with Skynopy



Credit: Eutelsat

Eutelsat has signed a partnership with French start-up Skynopy to transform the terrestrial segment of the space connectivity market. Often described as an "Airbnb for ground stations, Skynopy markets unused airtime from underutilised antennas and, through its software orchestration, enables satellites to connect seamlessly to any available ground station. Eutelsat now operates OneWeb's global ground infrastructure made up of 42 ground stations and 600 Ka-band antennas, which were mainly built for broadband connectivity rather than EO. The integration of Skynopy's software layer with Eutelsat's OneWeb ground station network allows EO satellites to downlink data through the dense OneWeb ground station network, enabling faster and more flexible data downlink.

Exolaunch to deploy 59 satellites on Transporter-15 rideshare mission



Credit: Exolaunch

Exolaunch has announced plans to deploy 59 customer satellites on Space X's upcoming Transporter-15 rideshare mission, scheduled to fly aboard a Falcon 9 rocket no earlier than November 2025. The launch will be Exolaunch's largest to date, supporting more than 30 commercial, institutional, and government customers from 16 countries. The mission will use Exolaunch's flight-proven deployment systems, including EXOpod Nova, CarboNIX, and Quadro, alongside the new CarboNIX NEO designed for heavier spacecraft.

Isar Aerospace signs launch contract with R-Space for GreenBox Satellites

Isar Aerospace has signed a launch contract with R-Space to launch the company's first two GreenBox satellites into orbit aboard its two-stage Spectrum rocket. Founded in 2021, R-Space provides a standardised payload service named GreenBox, which integrates customer technologies for in-orbit demonstration and validation. The partnership was facilitated through ESA's ScaleUp Marketplace initiative connecting New Space companies to accelerate commercialisation. The satellites are scheduled to be launched in Q2 2026, with options for further flights in 2026 and 2027.



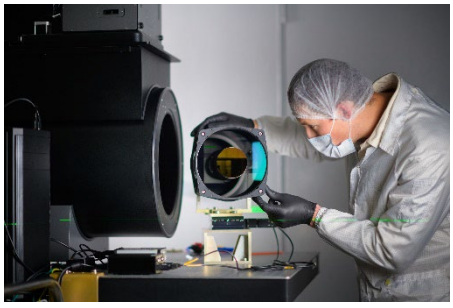
Credit: Isar Aerospace

GHGSat partners with ExxonMobil for methane monitoring

Emissions-monitoring company GHGSat has partnered with ExxonMobil Corporation to monitor and mitigate methane emissions across the corporation's onshore operations in North America and Asia. Collaboration between the two entities began in 2020 with field trials demonstrating space-based methane monitoring technology. ExxonMobil has made a "significant investment" in GHGSat's services and aims to cut methane emissions by 70-80% by 2030. Data collected by GHGSat will feed into ExxonMobil's Center for Operations and Methane Emissions Tracking (COMET).

Infinite Orbits selects Simera Sense to deliver payload for Orbit Guard mission

Infinite Orbits has selected South African satellite production company Simera Sense to provide an optical payload for its Orbit Guard mission, supported by the CNES-led France 2030 programme. Under the agreement, Simera Sense is responsible for providing a commercial payload from its proven xScape series to deliver non-Earth imaging for in-orbit satellite and debris monitoring. The partnership integrates Infinite Orbit's in-orbit services platform with Simera Sense's commercial optical technology, aiming to advance Europe's Space Situational Awareness (SSA) capabilities through innovative SmallSat-based solutions.



Credit: Simera Sense

Arianespace considers increasing launch rate of Ariane 6 rocket

Arianespace has been examining options to increase the launch rate of the Ariane 6 rocket above 10 per year if supported by government and commercial demands. Considerations to increase capacity are largely driven by major institutional programmes like Europe's IRIS2 and commercial constellations such as Amazon's Project Kuiper. Any expansion would require decisions within the next two years if higher cadence is needed by 2029-2030 and will depend on whether another large constellation project emerges in the coming years.

SpaceX acquires wireless spectrum licenses from EchoStar for $17 billion



Credit: EchoStar

Space X has announced its intention to purchase wireless spectrum licenses from EchoStar for approximately $17 billion, split evenly between cash and SpaceX stock, to expand Starlink's 5G connectivity. As part of the deal, SpaceX will also cover about $2 billion in interest payments on EchoStar's debt through 2027. The spectrum purchase will allow SpaceX to develop next-generation Starlink direct-to-device, laser-connected satellites, enabling over a hundredfold increase in capacity and supporting global 5G connectivity. Customers of EchoStar's terrestrial wireless service Boost Mobile will gain access to Starlink's direct-to-cell services.

EchoStar has abandoned its plans to develop its own $5 billion direct-to-device LEO satellite constellation and has cancelled a $1.3 billion contract with MDA Space for 100 satellites, plus a $1.2 billion option for 100 more. The agreement follows months of disputes between the two companies, with SpaceX challenging EchoStar's use of the spectrum, alleging underutilisation and prompting an FFC investigation. EchoStar has justified the transaction as a quicker, more economical way to realise the direct-to-cell vision for consumers worldwide. SpaceX intends to begin testing of new direct-to-device services as soon as the end of 2026.

Orano signs contract with Zeno Power for supply of space nuclear batteries



Credit: Zeno Power

French nuclear recycler Orano has signed a contract with nuclear battery startup Zeno Power to secure the steady supply of americium-241 (Am-241) for its long-duration space batteries. The contract provides Zeno Power with priority access to material recovered from used nuclear fuel in France, offering an alternative to scarce plutonium-238 used for many NASA missions. Zeno Power is developing radioisotope power systems (RPS) fuelled with americium, for NASA to support lunar rovers, landers, and infrastructure. Naturally derived from used nuclear fuel, Am-241's half-life of over 430 years enables power systems to operate for decades. The company aims to fly its first system by the end of the decade, following three years of work with Orano at its facility located in La Hague.

IN OTHER NEWS

Avio signs launch services agreement with SpaceLaunch

Italian rocket manufacturer Avio has signed a launch services agreement with US-based SpaceLaunch for a Vega C mission in 2027, set to carry an EO satellite for an institutional customer outside of Europe.

First Cygnus XL Cargo Module launches to ISS

On 14 September 2025, Northrop Grumann's NG-23 mission launched the first XL version of the Cygnus cargo spacecraft aboard a SpaceX Falcon 9 rocket, increasing transport capacity by 33% and enabling the delivery of more supplies to the ISS. The pressurised cargo module was built by Thales Alenia Space.

ICEYE demonstrates operational ISR Cell at NTM25

ICEYE has demonstrated its new mobile ISR Cell at NATO Tiger Meet 2025 (NTM25) in Portugal, showcasing near-real-time space-based intelligence for allied forces. The system aims to integrate space-based ISR to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of decision-making.

SpaceX launches 28 Starlink satellites into LEO

On 28 September 2025, SpaceX launched 28 new Starlink satellites aboard a Falcon 9 rocket from Vandenberg Space Force Base. The launch marked the company's 124th Falcon 9 mission of the year, expanding its constellation to more than 8,500 active satellites.

Blue Origin to increase New Shepard launch rate

Blue Origin plans to increase the launch cadence of its New Shepard suborbital vehicle to weekly within a few years and is considering new international spaceports to expand beyond its Texas site.

Eartheye to offer self-service tasking of satellites

Eartheye Space has announced it will begin offering self-service tasking of satellites looking into space as well as those focused on Earth. The platform enables customers to choose whether to look up or down within a single workflow, simplifying access to space situational awareness.

Galactic Energy raises $336 million for Ceres and Pallas launchers



Credit: Galactic Energy

Galactic Energy has secured $336 million in a Series D round invested in by several governmental, regional or municipal-backed funds such as the Beijing Commercial Spaceflight and Low-Altitude Economy Industry Investment Fund, the Sichuan Industry Revitalization Investment Group, and the Nanjing Innovation Investment Group. Galactic Energy.

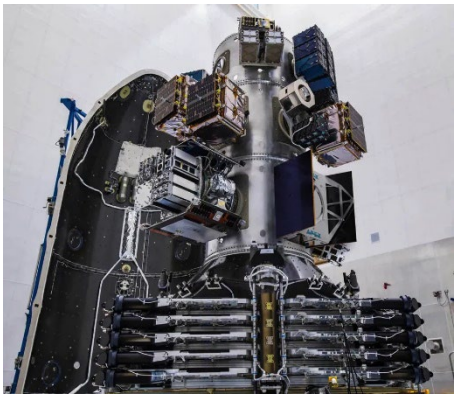
The Chinese start-up develops two series of launchers: Ceres, a light, expendable rocket whose first iteration has had 20 successful flights out of 21 attempted; and Pallas, a medium-lift, partially reusable launcher which is to be transported in November to Jiuquan spaceport ahead of a first test flight. The company also works on Ceres-2 and Pallas-2, both with increased capacity and planned to launch next year, in an attempt to secure Chinese megaconstellations contracts. The investment will enable further development on Ceres-2 and the Pallas series, as well as infrastructure and facilities.

Geespace secures approx. $281 million in strategic investment for IoT constellation

Geespace, or Spacetime Daoyu, a subsidiary of Chinese auto manufacturer Geely, has signed a strategic cooperation agreement with Zhejiang provincial government's Financial Holding Management, as well as Hangzhou High-Tech Jintou Holding Group and state-owned Hangzhou Capital Investment and Operation, raising CN¥2 billion (approx. $281 million) from Zhejiang New Energy Vehicle Industry Fund in the process. Geespace designs, builds and operates its Future Mobility Constellation, or GEESATCOM, a LEO IoT constellation of 52 satellites, **with a total objective of over 5000**. GEESATCOM will enable precise navigation and connectivity, including autonomous driving for Geely's electric vehicles, but also satellite-based services beyond the automotive sector, such as urban mobility, maritime, infrastructure monitoring, and emergency communication.

Geespace has established partnerships in the Middle East, Latin America, Africa, and South and East Asia, signing agreements with over 20 national operators. The funding will enable Geespace to build its global headquarters and development of its constellation.

Apex raises $200 million for serial production of small satellite buses



Credit: Apex Space

Apex Space has secured **$200 million in a Series D round** led by Interlagos. The U.S. start-up manufactures **three satellite buses:** Aries, able to carry up to 150 kg to LEO and GEO; Nova, able to carry up to 500 kg to LEO and whose first flight is expected next year; and Comet, announced in May 2025 and able to carry over 500 kg. The Series D comes only five months after a $200 million Series C. While the former round aimed at enhancing vertical integration, the capital raised will seek to increase production capacity to meet demand through the expansion of Apex Los Angeles facility – enabling a 50% reduction in lead time, the company states.

iSpace secures approx. $98 million for reusable launch vehicles



Credit: iSpace

Chinese company Interstellar Glory (iSpace) has raised CN¥700 million (approx. $98 million) in another tranche of its Series D round – initiated in March – led by Chengdu Advanced Capital. iSpace develops its Hyperbola series of reusable liquid launch vehicles, with a first iteration, Hyperbola-1, having had four failed launches out of eight attempted. The company decided to move on directly to medium-lift Hyperbola-3, **whose autonomous launch and recovery barge was completed in August 2025**. The investment will go towards further development of the launcher, with a March statement indicating a maiden flight in December 2025, as well as the construction of a production line in Chengdu, Sichuan, a province with which iSpace launched a strategic cooperation aiming at bolstering the regional commercial aerospace industry.

Hubble Network secures $70 million for Bluetooth constellation

Hubble Network has raised **$70 million in a Series B round** led by Ryan Swagar, co-founder and managing partner of Hinge Capital. The U.S. company builds and operates seven satellites enabling Bluetooth tracking capabilities, **connecting IoT devices emitting low-volume location data with the satellites' antennae**. The company has successfully demonstrated its technology in 2024 and currently works with ten pilot customers, targeting the shipping, logistics, construction, or outdoors recreation industries. Hubble seeks to launch 60 satellites total by 2028 and will direct the capital towards the growth of its customer base.

Cailabs raises €57 million for ground stations' production scale-up



Credit: Cailabs

Cailabs has secured **€57 million in financing**, including a €37 million loan from the European Investment Bank and a €20 million funding round gathering Definvest and the Fonds Innovation Defense (French Ministry of Defence and Bpifrance), as well as NewSpace Capital, the European Innovation Council, and others. The French start-up specialises in laser communications, manufacturing and operating optical ground stations (OGS) enabling fast space-to-ground connectivity. **Cailabs' technology was successfully demonstrated in May 2025**, following a partnership with Kepler Communications. The company, which can currently manufacture ten OGS a year, will leverage the funding to scale production through the opening of a new manufacturing plant in France to reach a yearly output of 50 OGS by 2027, expand its global footprint, and broaden its product offerings.

ReOrbit secures €45 million for sovereign space infrastructure

ReOrbit has raised **€45 million in a Series A round** led by Springvest. The Finnish start-up seeks to offer a sovereign infrastructure for space assets, designing both the hardware and software needed to control critical satellites and communication systems. The company places emphasis on sovereign and autonomous control, **and claims a contract worth "hundreds of millions" with a country, and "multiple MoUs" with others**. With an in-orbit demonstration planned next year for the European Space Agency, ReOrbit will use the funding to expand manufacturing capacity, boost R&D, and grow operations.

NoFence raises $35 million for herd monitoring

NoFence has secured **$35 million in an oversubscribed Series B round** led by the European Circular Bioeconomy Fund. The Norwegian start-up offers a virtual fencing system allowing farmers to define, move, and monitor pasture boundaries digitally through solar-powered GPS collars and a mobile app. The technology, leveraging cellular networks for communications as opposed to specific stations, also enables livestock tracking and more efficient rotational grazing, preventing resources depletion. NoFence, which has currently deployed over 150000 collars across Norway, the U.S., Spain and the UK, will leverage the investment to improve its technology and accelerate its market reach in Europe and especially in the U.S.

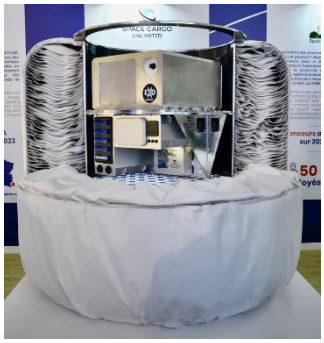
GHGSat announces approx. €29 million for greenhouse gas monitoring

GHGSat has secured **$47 million CAD in funding (approx. €29 million)**, with equity provided by Yaletown Partners and previous investors, and debt financing by National Bank of Canada and Export Development Canada. The Canadian start-up develops and operates a constellation of 14 satellites – as well as aircraft – monitoring greenhouse gases through methane and carbon dioxide detection. GHGSat offers its analytics to the energy, mining, finance, and waste industries, **notably partnering with oil and gas company ExxonMobil for onshore operations' monitoring**, and **providing services to NASA** under the Commercial SmallSat Data Acquisition programme. The capital will go towards international expansion and technology development.

Space Cargo Unlimited secures €27.5 million for in-space manufacturing platform

Space Cargo Unlimited has raised €27.5 million in a Series A round led by Expansion Ventures. The Luxembourg-based start-up develops an autonomous and return-capable platform, REV1, with a core module called BentoBox enabling microgravity research, in-space manufacturing and technology demonstration.

Space Cargo Unlimited seeks to offer a sovereign European solution to microgravity research and entrepreneurship following the retirement of the ISS. **REV1, designed in collaboration with Thales Alenia Space**, notably targets the agriculture and health industries and is planned for a first mission launch in Q4 2025. Funding allocation was not disclosed.



Credit: Space Cargo Unlimited

IN OTHER NEWS

K2 Space secures $15 million for multi-orbits satellites

The American start-up has raised $15 million in an investment from Luxembourg-based PE firm NewSpace Capital. K2 Space develops buses equipped with hall-effect propulsion systems, enabling orbit raises following rideshare launches, with a first customer mission, Gravitas, set to take off in 2026. Capital will serve in meeting European demand.

OrienSpace raises “hundreds of millions of yuan”

The Chinese start-up has raised “hundreds of millions of yuan” (CN¥100 million = approx. €12 million) in a Series B+ round to develop its Gravity series of launchers, whose first iteration successfully launched from a sea platform in January 2024. Orienspace currently works towards Gravity-2, with a first flight planned at the end of the year. Funding will go towards increased R&D to meet that objective.

Kreios Space secures €8 million for VLEO satellites

The Spanish start-up raised €8M in a Seed round co-led by NATO Innovation Fund and JOIN Capital to develop its air-breathing electric propulsion (ABEP) system, enabling longer satellite missions in VLEO without onboard propellant. The funding will support two test satellites and the first ABEP system demonstration.

ElevationSpace raises €6.3 million for re-entry platforms

The Japanese start-up has raised JP¥1.1B (≈€6.3M) in a Series B round to advance its ELS-R and ELS-RS re-entry capsule platforms for space-based research, manufacturing, and payload return. Backed by partnerships with Toyota Industries, JAXA, and Tohoku University, ElevationSpace plans to launch its first mission, **AOBA**, in late 2026. The funding will support hiring and development of AOBA and the capsule platforms.

Icarus Robotics raises $6.1 million for robotic labour force

The U.S start-up raised a $6.1M Seed round led by Soma Capital and Xtal. The startup builds AI-powered, fan-driven robotic assistants with jaw grippers to handle logistics in space, reducing astronauts’ workload. While funding use wasn’t disclosed, Icarus will test its robots on parabolic flights and deploy a prototype on the ISS with Voyager to gather training data.

LAUNCHES & SATELLITES

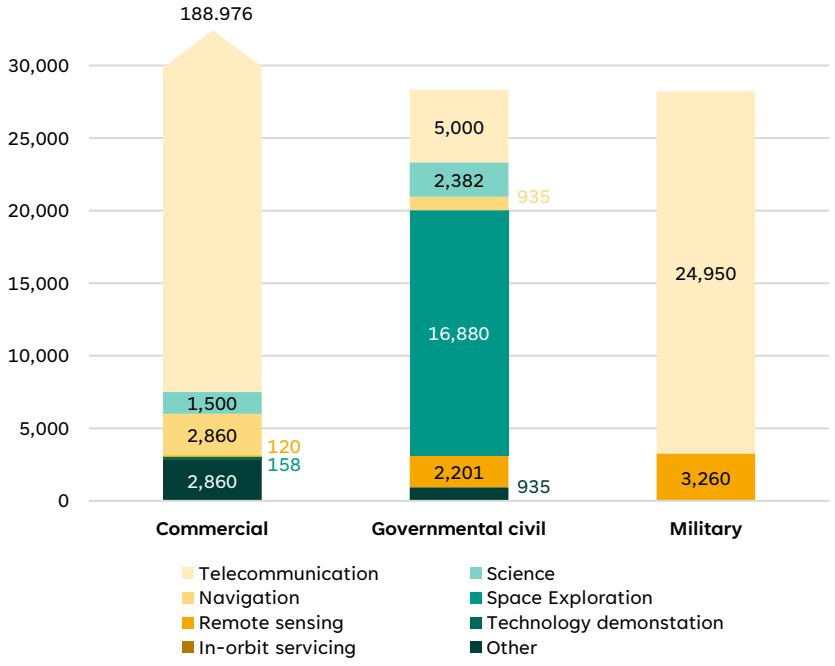
ESPI

Launch provider's region	USA	China	Europe	Russia	India	Japan	Others	Total
Number of launches	17	10	0	2	0	0	1	**30**
Number of spacecrafts launched	377	44	0	3	0	0	1	**425**
Mass launched (in kg)	226 073	17 270	0	8 285	0	0	260	**251 888**

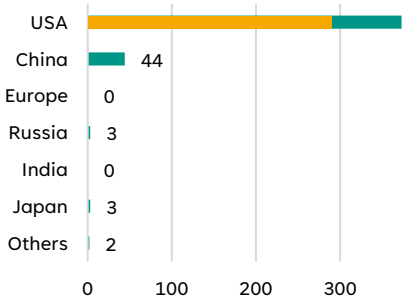
Top launch service providers of the month

1. SpaceX (16)
2. CASC (9)
3. Roscosmos (2)

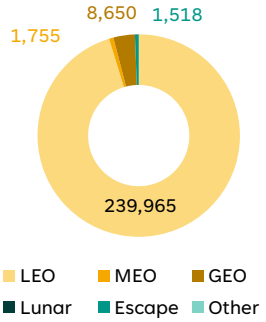
Mass launched (in kg) by market and by mission

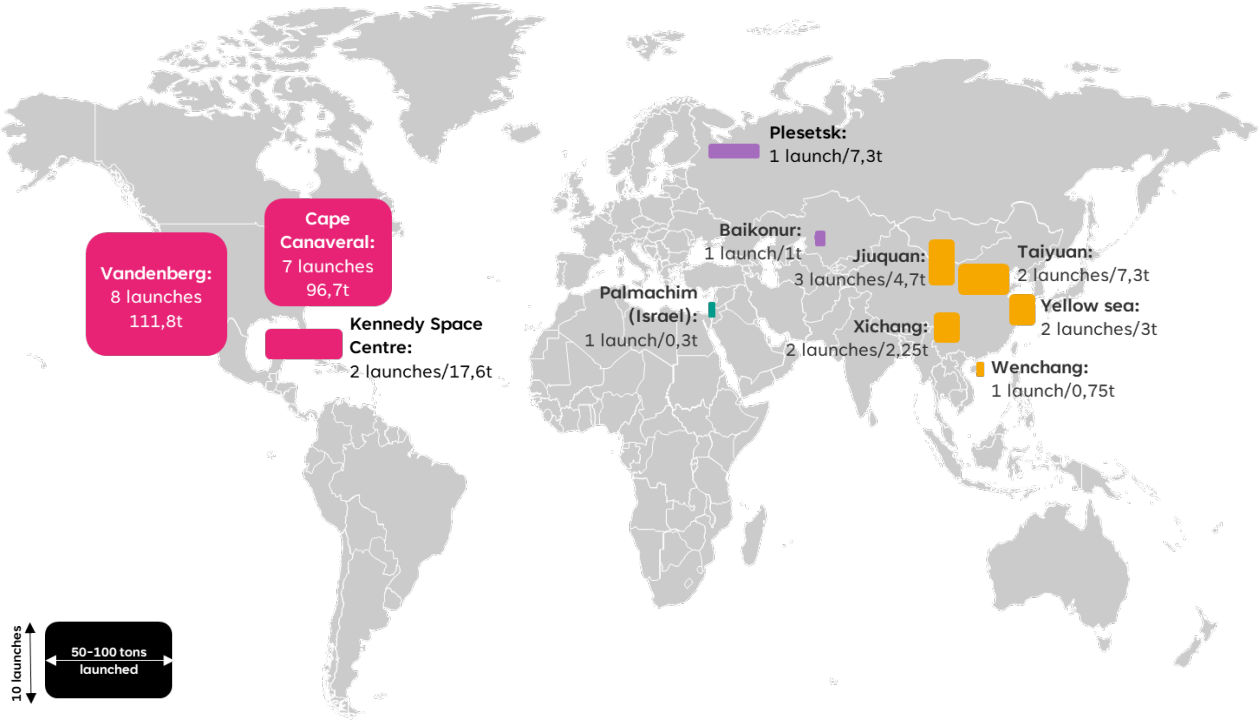


Number of spacecrafts launched by payload owner's region



Mass launched (in kg) by orbit





ESPI
Insights

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INVESTMENT & FINANCE
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